

# VIA NOVA

NEWSLETTER - FALL 2023

## Dear friends and family,

It has been such a joy to spend the past few months in Via Nova! I am so grateful that I get to spend this year intentionally focusing on building habits and skills before I choose my next step. With this newsletter, I hope to give everyone a closer look into what I've been up to and how I've been spending the past few months.

I've been able to get to know a lot of wonderful people through living in community, working with other artists in South Louisiana, and participating in the events that we have put on through Via. We have hosted several community dinners and events, including an All Saints Day party, poetry night, "dinner & discussions," and game nights. I've been living with two other ladies, which has been a lot of fun, and I've really enjoyed being able to open up our house to host others.



Learning how to make traditional Taiwanese dumplings at Braxton and Libby Callen's house with Every and All missionaries



The Via Fellows at Blue Lakes on the way to Mt. Sneffels



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# study

I have been really enjoying the topics we have studied so far! First, we studied the biblical narrative with Father John Joseph, CJC, covering a lot of Genesis and a few other Old Testament books, such as Esther and Ruth. We also read and studied the Babylonian texts the *Enuma Elish* and *The Epic of Gilgamesh* and then compared them with the Scriptures. Next, Deacon Adam Conque led a series of seminars on the prophets, and we really focused on the role of prophets in ancient Israel and also in our own time. After we concluded our study of Ancient Israel, each Fellow presented a 20-30 minute talk on a theme or idea related to what we discussed in seminar. We presented to many people including our families, former teachers, priests and other members of the community.

I chose to present on how the ancient Babylonian view of the afterlife and subsequent lack of hope for a savior affected the value system of the Babylonians and led to a significantly lacking vision of their purpose in life. This bleak worldview affected how the main character in one of our texts, Gilgamesh, reacted to the hardship and suffering in his own life, leading to even more unhappiness and discontentedness. On the other hand, Joseph and Job, two biblical characters we read about who encountered suffering, had much more hopeful reactions and were able to accept their suffering with faith that good could come from evil. I argued that their responses stemmed from their knowledge that a Savior will come and that eternal beatitude is attainable.

For the last several weeks, Father Guillory has been leading our seminars on Homer's *Odyssey*. This is my second time reading the *Odyssey*, but this time has been much more in-depth and included a lot more discussion and active participation.



Fr. Guillory leading a seminar on the *Odyssey* with the Fellows at the Via House

# work

This year, I am dedicating my time for work to turning my love for art into a career and building my portfolio for applying to art schools. I'm thankful to have a lot of freedom to explore different styles and mediums and expand my skill set. I have started by working on some commissions, and other personal pieces. If you would like to keep up with my art, you can follow my instagram [@rachelfriddellart](#), or visit my website [www.rachelfriddell.com](http://www.rachelfriddell.com)!



My booth at the Farmers Market at Moncus Park

I also had my first booth at the Lafayette Farmers Market on Saturday, November 18th. I really enjoyed seeing new and familiar faces and sharing about what I love to do! I am planning on having a booth on a regular basis, so you can plan on seeing me most Saturdays from 8am-12pm.

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For the past few months, I have been blessed to work with Blair Piras, the artist behind Blair Barlow Art. She is a sacred artist in Covington, LA and studied at the Sacred Art School in Florence, Italy. Blair was very gracious in taking me on as her apprentice and student this year!

I started my work with Blair in July helping her start a large commissioned piece. Over two days, we stretched, gessoed, and primed a 7'x9' canvas. It was a new experience for me and I learned a lot about what goes into the planning portion of oil painting.

In the last weekend in July, I coordinated an oil painting workshop led by Blair. She guided me and a few friends of mine, including my former art teacher, Erika Littell, through the whole process of painting a still life with oil paints.



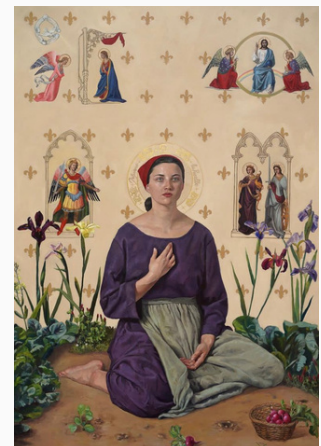
Pictures from our summer workshop

Since the beginning of September, I have been spending my Tuesdays in Covington working with Blair. For morning lessons, we have been having class at Abbey Art Works on the beautiful campus of St. Joseph's Abbey and Seminary College. So far, I have completed a graphite drawing of a plaster cast face and I am currently working on an oil study of a drapery still life. In the afternoon, I help her around her home studio if necessary or shadow her while she works on commissions. I have enjoyed getting a close up glimpse of Blair's creative process. I have helped her make a costume for a model for a commission, prepare prints for an exhibition, and shadowed her while she taught an art class to seventh graders.



me and Blair at the SL9 Soiree

This past November, I was privileged to attend the St. Louis IX Soiree in New Orleans. It was a great gift to me to learn a little more about SL9's mission and meet some very talented artists in Southern Louisiana. We are blessed to have many artists in Louisiana dedicated to the preservation of beauty and truth through their witness to the arts!



*St. Joan of Arc, Maiden of Orléans*  
One of my favorite pieces by Blair!



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# prayer

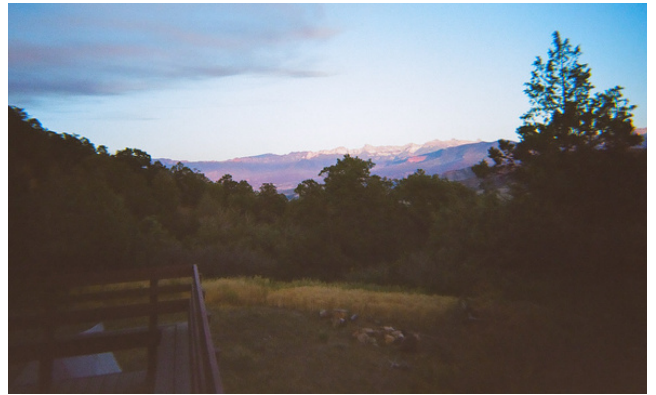
Every day, we are blessed to be able to spend at least 45 minutes in front of the Eucharist in silent prayer, attend daily Mass, and pray Compline as a community. We have also been able to go on two retreats this fall.

At the end of September, we traveled to Ridgway, Colorado for a retreat in the Rocky Mountains. On the way up, we stopped and spent a day at Clear Creek Abbey in Oklahoma. There, I got to experience the traditional latin liturgy for the first time, and we were able to pray multiple times a day with the monks.



Hiking through the beautiful fall colors with Ann-Ayrisse

We went on several small hikes, saw a waterfall, and hung out in the cute mountain towns. We attempted to climb a Class 3 fourteenner, Mount Sneffels. Unfortunately, I was not able to summit, but it was a beautiful hike, and I really enjoyed it!



A view from our cabin in Colorado



Sketching the mountain range from our cabin

The mountains are one of my favorite places to paint and get inspiration. The fall colors and foliage were absolutely incredible. It is very easy for me to see the hand of God when I'm surrounded by beauty. I'm especially grateful for all the time we had to be in silence and contemplation.

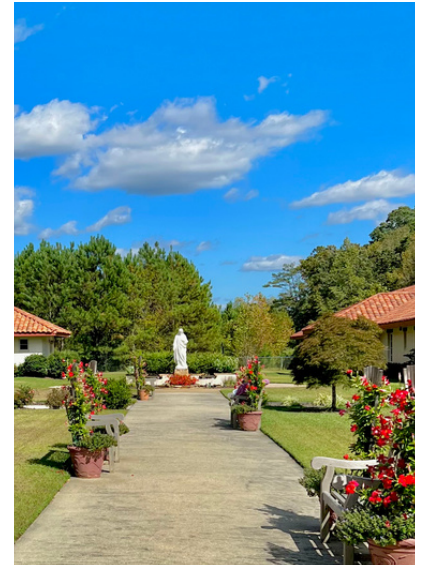


The hike up to Mt. Sneffels with the other Fellows



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In October, while the men's cohort went back to Our Lady of Clear Creek Abbey for the Three Hearts Pilgrimage, the women's cohort went on retreat at the Sister Servants of the Eternal Word in Irondale, Alabama. All of the sisters and the other retreatants were very kind and welcoming. Monsignor Eugene Morris led a really powerful series of talks on the topic of "The Art of Humility". We also had plenty of time for prayer and personal reflection which we could spend anywhere on the beautiful convent grounds. I had a really lovely time!



The grounds at Casa Maria, the Sister Servants' convent

I have had so many amazing opportunities for growth these past months and I've been able to see the Lord working in some really profound ways. None of this would be possible without the generosity and support of many people and I am grateful. I want to thank all of you who have been praying for me and walking with me during this time!

Know of my prayers for each one of you and if you ever have any special intentions you would like prayers for, I would love to pray for you. Don't hesitate to reach out!

In Christ,

**Rachel Friddell**

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